Prologue: The Three Classmates

In late July 2003, I stood in a funeral home near Cobham in Surrey, paying my last respects to a man called Karl Lavrenčič. As the coffin was quietly sliding into the mouth of the crematorium, I was overwhelmed by my emotions. In this English suburb the slightly insecure voices of an amateur male group, singing traditional Slovenian funeral hymns, were something from another world. Watching his family and friends, and the Slovenian Catholic priest from London who was conducting the service, the thought slipped through my mind that this man died in the wrong place. Despite all that Karl did for his native country, it was his dying in England – the country that had long ago become his new and (most probably) truest home – that really gave the impression that he had been finally and forever lost to his fatherland.

Karl Lavrenčič, dubbed 'adventurous World Service broadcaster',[1] and his wife Dora were very good to me. I do not recall exactly how I first met him. It must have been on one of his trips to Slovenia. Formally retired, he continued his freelance work for the Economist Intelligence Unit, for the Slovenian Section of the BBC and for other organisations. His work meant everything to him.

Every morning, there were papers from all over the world waiting on the doorstep of his home in Oxshott. And despite his age – he was over 70 at the time – he still used to travel around the globe. Annual IMF and World Bank gatherings in Washington were his staple food, as were monthly trips to Slovenia. There, he walked into my office one day at one of the newly-emerged political parties, where I was in charge of international affairs. From then on, we kept in touch, and I was a welcome visitor to his and Dora's home. During my studies at the University of London, I often spent weeks there preparing for the exams.

He and Dora lived a very comfortable life by the time they both retired. But it was not always like that. Karl came to the UK with little more than the clothes he stood up in. Dora, the daughter of a senior Slovenian politician from the years before World War II, did not fare much better. She came from a respected conservative family of Slovenian patriots; he was the